

Philosophy in the United States



A group of Boston intellectuals including (seated at front) Ralph Waldo Emerson, photographed in 1875.

Despite gaining its independence at the end of the 18th century, America retained an essentially European culture. But in the 19th century, an American intellectual tradition emerged, especially in the literary circles of New England. The nonconformist ideas of Ralph Waldo Emerson formed the basis for an idealist philosophy he called transcendentalism – a recognizably American version of Romanticism taken up by authors and poets including Henry Thoreau.

Towards the end of the century, US philosophy became more influenced by scientific thinking. Mathematician Charles Sanders Peirce and psychologist William James were at the forefront of the movement known as pragmatism, which took a practical approach to ideas of knowledge and truth, dismissing philosophizing that has no appreciable effect on our lives. This became the predominant 'home-grown' American philosophy of the 20th century, with applications in politics and education explored by figures such as John Dewey and Richard Rorty.